



MODULE 10

The reflective coach

How do you learn as a coach, and how do you know you're getting better?

CORE THEORY

Donald Schön (1983) distinguishes two forms of professional learning: reflection-in-action (adjusting during coaching) and reflection-on-action (analyzing afterward). Deliberate practice (Ericsson, 1993) shows that expertise comes not from experience alone, but from conscious, focused practice on weak points with immediate feedback. The best coaches are lifelong learners who systematically reflect, use peer-coaching, and employ video analysis.

Source: Schön (1983) · Ericsson (1993) · Cushion et al. (2010) · Côté & Gilbert (2009)

"A coach who stops learning is a coach who has stopped coaching. They just don't know it yet."

John Wooden

"It's not the experience that makes you better. It's the evaluated experience."

John Maxwell

SELF-REFLECTION

- 1 How do you learn as a coach today? Name three concrete sources of growth you have used in the past year.
- 2 When did you last analyze your own training or game, with video or notes?
- 3 Who is your coach? Who guides you in your growth as a coach?
- 4 What is the biggest gap between who you want to be as a coach and who you are now? What are you actively doing to close it?
- 5 Looking back over five years of coaching: what have you fundamentally changed in your approach? What triggered that change?

NOTES

**BOOKS**

- **Peak**
Anders Ericsson & Robert Pool
Why: The science of deliberate practice. How the best in their field become who they are, and what this means for your own growth as a coach.
- **Range**
David Epstein
Why: Broad experiences make better coaches. Counter to overspecialization. Rewrites the early vs. late specialization debate.
- **The Reflective Practitioner**
Donald Schön
Why: The foundation of professional learning. How experts learn through doing and reflecting. Academic but indispensable.
- **Bounce**
Matthew Syed
Why: Talent is a myth. Deliberate practice, mental strengths, and the role of coaches in shaping champions.

**VIDEO'S / TED TALKS**

- **The Making of an Expert**
Anders Ericsson (Stanford)
[youtube.com/results?search_query=anders+ericsson+deliberate+practice+talk](https://www.youtube.com/results?search_query=anders+ericsson+deliberate+practice+talk)
Deliberate practice vs. naive practice. Most coaches do the second. Do you want to do the first?
- **Atul Gawande on Coaching**
Atul Gawande (New Yorker Talk)
[youtube.com/results?search_query=atul+gawande+coaching+newyorker](https://www.youtube.com/results?search_query=atul+gawande+coaching+newyorker)
Why even the best surgeons need a coach. Do you have a coach?

**PODCASTS**

- **The James Clear Podcast**
Habits and systems for continuous growth as a professional
jamesclear.com/podcast
- **The Tim Ferriss Show**
Episode with Anders Ericsson: how experts become experts
tim.blog/podcast

⚡ ACTION THIS WEEK

Start a coaching journal. After every training/game, write 3 things: (1) What went well and why? (2) What would I do differently? (3) What does this teach me about myself as a coach?

My plan to reflect more systematically on my coaching this season: